

How to Read About AI

Navigate the noise without losing your footing

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A short guide to reading AI news without losing your footing - what to trust, what to skim, what to ignore.

The Problem With AI News

AI generates more headlines than almost any other topic right now. Most of those headlines are written to provoke a reaction - fear, excitement, urgency. Almost none of them are written to help you understand what is actually happening and what it means for your life.

The Three Types of AI Stories

Benchmark stories

'AI beats humans at X.' Usually true but often meaningless for daily life. Ask: Does this capability matter to me right now?

Prediction stories

'AI will change everything / take all jobs / solve cancer by [year].' These are speculations dressed as facts. Mark the author and revisit in 12 months.

Application stories

'Company uses AI to do X.' These are the most useful. Focus here - real use cases you can learn from.

5 Questions to Ask Before You React

- Who wrote this, and what do they get out of your reaction?
- Is this a study result, a product announcement, or an opinion?
- What does the headline claim vs. what does the article actually say?
- How big was the sample, and how controlled was the test?
- What would the opposite headline look like - and is it also true?

Sources Worth Your Time

No source is perfect. But these tend to be more careful than most:

MIT Technology Review - technologyreview.com - longer, more nuanced pieces

The Gradient - thegradient.pub - research-adjacent, technical but readable

Import AI (newsletter) - Jack Clark's weekly - dense, one of the best

Ars Technica - arstechnica.com - strong on how things actually work

What You Can Safely Ignore

- Headlines that contain BOMBSHELL, TERRIFYING, GAME CHANGER or a countdown
- Any story about AI sentience from a non-peer-reviewed source
- Predictions with specific timelines from people who have been wrong before
- Company press releases published as news without independent verification

The One-Line Test

Before sharing any AI story, ask yourself: 'Can I explain in one sentence what actually happened, what it means, and why it matters?' If you cannot, you are probably sharing the reaction, not the information.